CHAO FA · THE PRINTED FIRST GAME

The First Winter

> *Spring 1975. The village burned in the night. Four of us walked out before the soldiers came back: Chai the Senglao, Mai from the fields, Chao who can run, and old Blong who knows the paths. We took what we could carry. Chai says we are going south, to the river, and that the story cloth will show us the way. I will tell it as it happened, so the children remember.*

This booklet plays the first four seasons for you, one rule at a time, with the same cards the app's Learn to play uses. Read a season, do what the box says, and read the diary line it leaves behind. After Winter 1975 you shuffle everything and go on alone. The rulebook is the reference; you will not need it until then.

Setting the table

1. **The map.** Village Ruins face up at the top. Lay the hills row face down, left to right: **Pine Ridge, Swidden Fields, Long Tieng Airstrip**. The jungle, lowlands and river rows are shuffled face down as usual.
2. **The family.** Chai, Mai, Chao and Blong, all on **Side A**, each on a family board. Each takes the first of their own items out of its search deck: Chai the **Soul Lock**, Mai the **Hoe**, Chao the **Slingshot**, Blong the **Cane**. Set each HP cube on the card's HP.
3. **Tracks.** Food **12**, Hope **3**, the time marker on season 1. Squares **1 to 4** of the story cloth on the mat (a party of four starts with four).
4. **The stacked decks.** Shuffle every search deck, then find these cards and put them on top **in this order, first card on top** (the rest of each deck stays shuffled beneath):

VILLAGE RUINS, TOP 6

1. Needles
2. Soldiers searching the ruins (Danger, easy)
3. French Silver Coins
4. Village Flintlock
5. Wood Axe
6. Ring

PINE RIDGE, TOP 8

1. Bow
2. A Hidden Path (Escape)
3. Nothing but pine needles
4. A tiger on the ridge (Danger, easy)
5. Pine-Resin Torch
6. Horse
7. Wild mushrooms and a bird: Food +1
8. A hunter's shelter: DEF +2

SEASON DECK, TOP 4

1. Food +1
2. Food +2
3. A Sweep Through the Hills (Time)
4. A Crying Child (Dilemma)

THE FORTUNE DECK, ALL 20, TOP FIRST

17	6	10	14	5	18	3	9	7	19
8	2	16	12	4	11	1	15	13	20

Red cards favour the soldiers in a fight, blue the party.

Put the fight tracker, the Patrol table card (face 1, 1975 and 1976, the marker on **4** living) and this booklet beside the board. Laws, Strangers, Turning Points and River cards stay in the box this game.

The one idea. Every season is the same three steps: draw a **Season card**, everyone takes **two actions** (Travel instead, before anyone acts), then the **end of the season**. In Winter the end of the season is where the game bites: everyone eats, the Toll comes, the council meets.

Season 1 · Spring 1975 · *nplooj hlav*

We hid in the ruins all morning. Chai went back for the things we had left behind.

Season card: turn the top card: **Food +1**. Move Food to 13. Discard it.

1. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches the village (pay 1 Food, now 12). The first card is the **Needles**: Chai keeps them (an item with a villager's name goes to that villager if they are alive; Bao is not with this family, so anyone may hold them. Lay them on a pack slot of his board).
2. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches again (Food 11). The village has been searched once, so **first draw a Fortune card for noise**: a **17**. Higher than 1, so no one hears. The card is **Soldiers searching the ruins**: an **Easy fight**, now.

The first fight, on the tracker. Step 1: the Patrol table, Easy row, column 4, face 1: the soldiers are **4**. Put the brass marker on 4. The party's cards and items add up to **13 ATK, 14 DEF, 6 HP**: write them in. Step 2, clash 1: draw a Fortune card: a **6**, an even clash. You deal 13 − 4 = **9**, more than 4: the soldiers fall. They deal 4 − 14, nothing, but **always at least 1**: give the wound to **Chai** (move his HP cube from 2 to 1). Step 3: won in one clash. Easy means **1 safe search**: take the next card that is not a Danger: the **French Silver Coins**, to Chai.

3. **Forage Mai** forages (free): the village gives 1 Food in Spring, +1 for working: **Food +2** (now 13). Draw a Fortune card for being spotted: a **10**, above 3, safe.
4. **Scout Mai** scouts (Food 12): turn the left-hand hills tile face up: **Pine Ridge**. The party can travel there next season.
5. 🔍 **Search Chao** searches (Food 11): noise draw **14**, safe; he finds the **Village Flintlock** (both hands). Searches again (Food 10): noise draw **5**, above 3, safe; the **Wood Axe**.
6. 🔍 **Search Blong** searches (Food 9): noise draw **18**; the **Ring**. Then **Rest or nurse** he **rests and tends Chai**: Chai's cube goes back to 2.

End of the season: nobody is sick, it is not Winter. Move the time marker to 2. *Diary line 1: "Spring 1975. The ruins. Soldiers found Chai in the ashes; we drove them off. Food 9."*

Season 2 · Summer 1975 · the rains

The rains came and the paths turned to mud. Blong said he knew an old road over the ridge, from before the war.

Season card: Food +2 (Food 11).

1. **Travel Travel**, before anyone acts: the whole party moves to **Pine Ridge**. Normally you draw a Fortune card against the tile's Danger (2): on 2 or less a patrol finds you. Not today: **Blong's Side A power, Old Road**, is a reaction: no Danger draw, and 1 more Food on the way. Blong's power token goes to **used**.
2. On the way you gather the ridge's Summer forage: 1, +1 for working, +1 from Blong: **Food +3**. The journey eats 1. Food **13**.

End of the season: travelling takes the whole season. Time marker to 3. *Diary line 2: "Summer 1975. Up the old road to Pine Ridge. Blong remembered every turn."*

What you learned. Searching is how you find everything, and every search after the first makes **noise**. Hard work **eats**: Search, Scout, Camp and Travel cost 1 Food. A **power** is used once a season; the family board shows whether it is ready.

Season 3 · Fall 1975 · *nplooj zeeg*

Soldiers came through the hills in a line, beating the grass. We lay under the leaves all day and did not speak.

Season card: A Sweep Through the Hills, a Time card: this season everyone has **1 action** and the party cannot Travel.

1. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches the ridge (Food 12): the first search here, no noise draw. The **Bow** (both hands; give it to **Mai**, whose hands are free: handing on a found item is free).
2. **Forage Mai** forages: Fall on the ridge is 1, +1: **Food +2** (14). The spotting draw is a **3**: **spotted**. An **ambush**, Easy.

The second fight: an ambush. Soldiers 4 again (Easy, 4 living, face 1); the party is now **17 ATK, 16 DEF, 8 HP** (the Bow and the Flintlock count). **Ambush: they fire first**, so in clash 1 you deal nothing. Clash 1: Fortune **9**, even. They deal 4 − 16, at least 1: Chai takes it (cube to 1). Clash 2: Fortune **7**, even. You deal 17 − 4 = 13: the soldiers fall. They deal 1 again: Chai (he has nothing left to lose but his life, and 1 HP is still alive). Won in two clashes: **1 safe search**: **A Hidden Path**, an Escape card. Chai keeps it in hand: when soldiers find you, discard it and there is no fight.

3. **Build a camp Chao** starts a camp (Food 13): the first of two actions. Lay a Camp token on the tile, half turned.
4. 🔍 **Search Blong** searches (Food 12): noise draw **19**, safe. **Nothing but pine needles**: discard it. The deck gets thinner.

End of the season. Time marker to 4, a Winter cell. *Diary line 3: "Fall 1975. The sweep. Mai was seen gathering; Chai took the bullets. Chao began a shelter."*

Season 4 · Winter 1975 · *ntuj no*

The cold came down off the ridge. A child in the next family would not stop crying, and the soldiers were on the path below.

Season card: A Crying Child, a Dilemma. The party decides together before anyone acts. Choose **Hold the child and run**: Hope −1 (now 2), and draw a Fortune card: an **8**, 10 or less, so the soldiers come: a **Medium fight**.

The third fight. Medium row, column 4, face 1: the soldiers are **5**. Party 17 ATK, 16 DEF, 6 HP (Chai is on 1). Clash 1: Fortune **2**: **the soldiers' aim is true, +2**: they strike with 7. You deal 17 − 5 = 12: they fall. They deal 7 − 16, at least 1: give it to **Mai** (cube 2 to 1). Medium means **2 safe searches**: the **Pine-Resin Torch** and the **Horse** (the Horse is shared: no slot).

1. **Build a camp Chao** finishes the camp (Food 11): turn the Camp token face up. The Toll is 1 better here and resting heals 1 more.
2. **Rest or nurse Mai** rests and tends Chai: he heals **2** at the finished camp (cube back to 2: full).
3. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches (Food 10): noise draw **16**, safe. **A tiger on the ridge**: an Easy fight. Soldiers' number 4 (the table is used for animals too). Clash 1: Fortune **12**, even: 17 − 4 wins at once; 1 wound to Chai. 1 safe search: **Wild mushrooms and a bird, Food +1** (11).
4. **Rest or nurse Blong** rests and tends Chai (heals 1). **Rest or nurse Mai** rests (heals 1: full).
5. 🔍 **Search Chai** searches again (Food 10): noise draw **4**, above 3, safe. **A hunter's shelter, DEF +2**: into Chai's hand for a later fight.
6. **Rest or nurse Chao** rests, **Rest or nurse Blong** rests: nothing to heal, but Winter is no time to make noise.

The end of Winter: eat, the Toll, the council

1. **Eat.** Everyone eats 1 Food: 4 from the store, **Food 6**. Nobody goes hungry.
2. **The Toll.** Winter 1975 is the mildest: cold +0. Each villager draws a Fortune card and falls **Sick on 5 or less**, adjusted: +1 for a child (Chao) or an elder (Blong), −1 for the finished camp. In card order: Chai draws **11**, safe. Mai draws **1: Sick**. Put a Sick token in the box on her board: one action a season until she is nursed, and if the Toll takes her again she dies. Chao draws **15** (needed 5: safe), Blong **13** (needed 5: safe).
3. **The council.** Draw 2 laws: **Travel Light** (each person keeps at most 3 items; every Danger draw is 2 better) and **Council of Elders** (+1 Hope at every year end, but 1 Food is cooked for the council). Adopt one, or neither; it cannot be undone. The family in this diary chose Travel Light and left the Needles and the Coins under a stone.
4. Move the time marker to **5, Spring 1976**. Everyone who ate heals 1 wound in Spring.

Diary line 4: "Winter 1975. The cold took Mai. We ate the last of the rice. Chai says the river is four rows south and the soldiers will be twice as many next year."

Now shuffle everything and go on. Shuffle the Fortune deck and every search deck (keep the cards already drawn out), shuffle the Season deck, and put the Laws, Strangers and Turning Points beside the board. From here the game is yours: nurse Mai, scout the hills, find the keys that recover squares 5 to 9, and reach the river before the twentieth season. Keep writing the diary. When the game ends, the diary is read first, then the Endings booklet.

What the four seasons taught

A season is a Season card, two actions each (one if Sick; Travel instead, before anyone acts), then the end of the season. Winter adds eating, the Toll and the council.

Searching finds everything, and every search after the first draws for noise: earlier searches here or less brings soldiers. Spoils after a won fight are free and skip Danger cards.

A fight is one number from the Patrol table, up to three clashes with a Fortune card each, and the cost. Gunfire always gets through: at least 1 wound a clash. Armor stops it first.

Hard work eats. Search, Scout, Camp and Travel each cost 1 Food. Forage is free and brings Food in. In Winter everyone eats 1.

The Toll is a Fortune card per person at every Winter, Sick on 5 or less, worse for children, elders, the hungry, the wounded, the cold of the year and low Hope; better with a camp, a healer and warm things.

Keys and the cloth. Keys in the search decks recover the squares of the story cloth, each behind a fight one step harder than the place, or a price. With all nine, cross from any river place.

If the table disagrees with this booklet

The booklet is right only if the decks were stacked as page 1 says and the actions were taken in this order. If a draw comes out differently, you have skipped a draw or taken one too many: go back to the last matching line, or simply play on with the rules; the engine that checked this game would have done the same.

The same four seasons can be played on screen: the app's Learn to play uses this shuffle with the coach beside the table.

CHAO FA · START IN TWO MINUTES

Your first season

The table

1. **Board** on the table, Village Ruins face up at the top. Each row below: shuffle its four tiles, lay three face down, put one back.
2. **Search decks**: each place's deck shuffled, face down on its tile (the divider names it).
3. **Family boards**, one each: a villager card in the window, Side A up, the HP cube on the card's HP. Each villager takes the first of their own items from its deck.
4. **Tracks**: Food 3 per villager, Hope 3, the time marker on season 1, the phase marker on 1. Squares already sewn on the cloth mat: 2 for six villagers, 3 for five, 4 for four, 5 for three.
5. **Beside the board**: the Fortune deck shuffled face down, the Patrol table (face 1), the fight tracker, the Laws, Strangers, Turning Points and River cards in their dividers.

One season, read aloud

1. **Season card.** Turn the top card and do what it says. An Omen goes on the Omen row.
2. **Travel?** Before anyone acts, the party may move to a face-up place ahead (1 Food): a Fortune card against its Danger, then the season ends.
3. **Two actions each**: Search (1 Food), Scout (1 Food), Forage, Rest, Camp (1 Food), a Side A power, play a card.
4. **A fight**: one number from the Patrol table; up to three clashes with a Fortune card each; you choose who is hit.
5. **Winter only**: eat 1 Food each, then the Toll (a Fortune card each, Sick on 5 or less), then the council adopts a law.
6. **Time marker** forward one. After season 20 the game ends. The river needs all nine squares.

The goal. Recover the nine squares of the story cloth (keys in the search decks, each behind a fight or a price) and cross the Mekong from any river place before the end of 1979. Most who set out will not reach the far bank; the game is about who does, and how.

The four pages before this one play the first year for you, card by card. The rulebook has the rest; the symbol key cards explain every mark.